

Pressure

A Study in the Strategy of Linith



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First Edition
5AE

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Introduction

Linith is a game of compression and breath. Each turn narrows the living space between two Forces, the Sun and the Moon, until one side falls into stillness. It is not a contest of capture or removal, but of control and inevitability.

Every Swan you place expands your reach, yet every Stone you lay constrains it. Progress comes not from aggression but from shaping the field so that motion itself becomes impossible.

To play well is to think beyond the next move. It is to see how space will collapse several turns ahead, how freedom turns to confinement, and how the final victory is not seized but allowed to occur.

Chapter 1



The Nature of Linith

Linith is a contest of motion and stillness between two Forces, the Sun and the Moon. It resembles Chess and Go in its depth but not in its mechanics. Where Chess rewards capture and Go rewards territory, Linith rewards control through immobilisation.

The goal is not to attack but to remove all movement from the opposing Swans. Every decision concerns the shaping of space, and every space that remains open determines whether stillness or motion dominates the board.

Improvement in Linith is understanding that the game is about options. Each Swan, Stone, and silver represents a potential exchange of control. The best players sense which areas will matter three or four turns later, and act to limit those before the opponent realises they are closing.

Chapter 2



The Value of Space

The board's grey tiles represent potential. A single empty tile may become a bridge, an escape, or a boundary.

When a Stone is placed, it removes that potential; when a Swan moves, it shifts the meaning of the surrounding grey tiles.

In Linith, advantage comes from controlling how many neutral tiles each player can still use. This control is measured through silvers, the number of empty tiles adjacent to active Swans.

When silvers vanish, stillness begins. Playing well means always counting these silvers, not only for your own Swans but for the opponent's. A healthy position maintains several open directions of motion while reducing those of the enemy.

Good spatial play makes future encirclement inevitable without forcing it immediately.

Chapter 3



The First Swan

The opening determines tempo and structure. The Sun places the first Swan anywhere, and the Moon must respond by choosing a location not adjacent to it. This restriction defines the first geometry of the game.

A central placement for the Sun increases reach and flexibility but exposes the first Swan to encirclement from multiple directions. A corner placement grants safety but restricts growth.

The Moon's first placement is the first act of opposition; it defines where conflict will occur. The best response is usually not to mirror the Sun, but to place a Swan slightly offset from the centre, where it can expand safely while limiting the Sun's expansion routes.

These early placements form the foundation for all later structure. Once both sides have six Swans, their ability to place more disappears, so the quality of these initial networks determines long-term strength.

Chapter 4



Growth and Formation

During the early turns, growth is the primary goal. Each new Swan must be orthogonally adjacent to an existing one and cannot touch an enemy Swan, even diagonally.

This rule favours chain structures that extend along rows and columns. Compact clusters may feel secure but limit future placements; long chains may reach far but become brittle.

Effective play balances expansion with cohesion. A player who spreads too quickly leaves isolated Swans that are easy to surround. One who clusters too tightly will soon find no room to grow.

In this phase, Stones should rarely be placed. Every early Stone locks potential growth, including your own.

The best early strategy is to build a flexible shape with two to three routes of safe extension while keeping enough distance from the opponent to avoid adjacency traps.

Chapter 5



The Circle

Encirclement in Linith arises gradually. A Swan becomes frozen when all eight tiles around it are occupied or blocked by edges, Stones, or opposing pieces.

The process leading to that moment is called circle pressure, the slow reduction of enemy silvers until there are none left.

To apply pressure, place Stones or Swans in ways that close access to open grey tiles. The objective is not to freeze immediately but to deny movement incrementally.

The AI consistently favours advancing Stones that increase circle pressure or reduce opponent silvers. Moves that do not affect either are ignored. Strategic progress in Linith is measured by spatial compression, not material exchange.

To improve, think in layers. Each turn should shrink the space the opponent can safely use whilst expanding or maintaining your own. Victory follows naturally once that ratio is irreversible.

Chapter 6



Freezing and the Board

When a Swan or group is encircled, it freezes. Frozen Swans cannot move or spawn, but they remain on the board as barriers. These barriers change the landscape of the game.

A frozen enemy Swan can protect your flank by blocking new placements; a frozen friendly Swan can trap you by occupying the same role.

The art of stillness is to freeze the opponent without freezing yourself. Before every placement, imagine how the frozen shape will influence later movement.

Encircling an enemy Swan grants an extra action for that turn, so timing is critical. Freezing a single Swan while holding an unused action can allow an immediate secondary strike elsewhere.

Avoid chasing frozen groups that no longer threaten you. Once stillness is achieved, shift focus to where motion still exists.

Chapter 7



Coordination and Flow

Swans can move together. Selecting multiple Swans and moving them in the same direction allows entire formations to shift. Stones adjacent to these Swans follow them, provided they are not shared with an unmoved friendly Swan, or with an enemy Swan.

This rule means formations can drag boundaries forward, redrawing the shape of the field.

Effective players think in flows rather than single pieces. Moving a pair of Swans one tile up may pull several Stones and create a new wall that compresses the opponent's space.

Poor coordination leads to conflict amongst Stones, where shared adjacency prevents them from moving. Maintaining clear separation between groups ensures smoother movement later.

Every motion should alter the structure of influence, not just position. Movement that does not improve silvers or pressure wastes tempo.

Chapter 8



Momentum and Chain Actions

When both sides have six Swans, each turn allows for two actions. Freezing an enemy Swan also grants an additional action, creating moments of accelerated control.

The best players plan sequences that anticipate this momentum. Freezing an enemy Swan with the first action and using the bonus to close another gap can decide the game.

Momentum management is about timing. Ending a turn with unused options is better than forcing an unstable encirclement that gives the opponent space to recover.

Think of the game not as alternating single moves but as a rhythm of expansions and compressions. Each phase of acceleration should secure a lasting positional advantage before slowing again.

Chapter 9



Learning from the AI

The Linith AI does not calculate exhaustive futures. It evaluates states based on measurable pressure and potential. It counts silvers, measures the density of Stones around enemy Swans, checks whether new Stones advance the circle, and rewards positions that improve freedom for its own side.

Studying the AI's moves reveals its hierarchy of priorities:

1. Prevent being frozen.
2. Reduce opponent silvers.
3. Strengthen internal structure.
4. Advance Stones that close empty rings.
5. Avoid actions that do not change pressure.

To learn from it, play matches on different difficulty levels and observe when it chooses to place a Stone versus when it moves Swans. Each decision is a lesson in evaluating space without emotion.

By understanding why the AI ignores certain areas, you learn where real influence lies.

Chapter 10



Balance and Foresight

Mastery of Linith is in restraint. Every strong position results from many turns of patience.

The goal is not constant motion but inevitable stillness. A single misjudged placement can expose a Swan to encirclement several turns later.

Each move must serve both immediate defence and future confinement. The winning player is often the one who last needs to move, because their shape already denies all paths of escape.

To improve, practice reading the board several layers deep, which areas are open, which are sealed, and which are closing.

In Linith, foresight is space itself. Control it, and stillness follows.